

A FIRST-CHAPTER PREVIEW

ROOM 104

The Year We Looked Up

BOOK FOUR OF THE ARCHITECTURE OF GRACE

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CHAPTER ONE

The First Day of High School

MARCUS



The high school is the biggest building I have ever walked into. Three stories. Twelve hundred students. East and west wings. A cafeteria that seats four hundred. A gym with a track around the top.

I am fourteen. I am the smallest version of fourteen I think it is possible to be. I have not had my growth spurt. My voice has half-changed, which is worse than not having changed at all, because it cracks at random moments and is, several times a day, a thing I cannot control. I am wearing a clean shirt and pants my mom picked out with me last night. My backpack is new. The new backpack is, I now realize standing in this hallway, both a thing I wanted and a thing that announces *I am new* to every other kid in the building.

I walked to the corner with Sofia. We have been doing the walk to school together since first grade. The walk now ends at a bus stop instead of a sidewalk in front of the school. The bus takes ten minutes.

On the bus, I sit next to Sofia. Amara sits in front of us. Theo across the aisle. Priya three rows back. We are not the only freshmen, and we are not even most of the freshmen — there are sophomores and juniors and seniors, louder than us, who own the back of the bus.

I am quiet. Sofia is quiet. Amara is quiet.

The bus pulls into the school's circle. We get off.

The hallway, when we walk in, is big. The hallway is loud. The hallway is full of kids I do not know. I can feel myself, in my body, doing a thing I did not know I was going to do — I am scanning the hallway for any kid I recognize. Any face from the cohort.

I find Amara, right next to me. Sofia, right next to me. Theo, walking with us. Maya, at her locker in the freshman hallway, in a soft gray sweater, looking weirdly like she has been here for years. Priya, walking up with Hannah. Jordan, at his locker three down from Maya's. Darius, last to come in because he takes a different bus. Kezia, behind Darius, in her green hoodie — small, like me, but carrying herself like she has been ready for high school for a long time.

Nine of us. We are in the freshman hallway. The tenth — Mia — is in Pittsburgh, and is going to be in Pittsburgh for the rest of high school. I have not, until this moment, felt the tenth missing in a long time. I feel it now. The cohort, in a building this big, is — for the first time in years — visibly nine. Not ten.

I push the thought down.

Amara opens her locker. She has, in twenty-four hours, already decorated it — a small photo of her grandmother, a small piece of yellow construction paper that says, in her handwriting, AMARA. The yellow paper is — and I notice it because I am Marcus, and I notice these things — the same shade of yellow as the bench-sign Amara designed in third grade.

I think: Amara is bringing the bench-sign yellow to high school. Amara is starting the architecture from day one.

I open my locker. The cohort is, by alphabetical accident, scattered across the freshman hallway. Sofia is in the next aisle over. Theo and I are next to each other. Maya is on the other end. I put my backpack in. I take out my schedule.

First period — Algebra I, Mr. Owens, Room 218.

Second period — English I, Ms. Calloway, Room 104.

I had not let myself focus on this until now. Ms. Calloway is teaching freshman English. Ms. Calloway, somehow, has moved up to the high school. Eight years she has had us, and now a ninth. I do not know if all nine of us are in the same section. The school sometimes splits the cohort up.

I have to wait until second period to find out. I close the locker.

I walk with Sofia to first period, and we split up at the stairs. Sofia is in Honors Bio, up. I am in Algebra I, down the first floor.

Mr. Owens's classroom is at the end of a long hallway. I get there four minutes before the bell. Mr. Owens is younger than I expected — maybe thirty. Tie. Stack of textbooks on the desk. I sit in the third row.

Nobody in this room is from the cohort.

I scan. There is a girl in the front row I might have seen at a middle-school basketball game. A boy across from me in a Lincoln Park Track Team t-shirt — sophomore, probably. Other than that — twenty-six kids, none of whom I know.

This is, I now realize, the first classroom of my life in which I do not have a member of the cohort. The cohort has been in every classroom I have been in, one way or another, since first grade. This room is twenty-six strangers and me.

I feel — and I notice that I am feeling it — the small adolescent panic of *who am I going to be in this room*. The room has never seen the version of me the cohort has seen for eight years. The room is going to meet a new Marcus, and that Marcus is going to be — what? Quiet? Loud? Funny?

The Marcus the room is going to see is, I now realize, whatever Marcus I decide to be in the first three weeks. The room will form an opinion by mid-September and that opinion will be sticky.

I have been the kid who tells the truth, since I was eight. That is who I have been in the cohort. The cohort knows that about me. The cohort sees me through that lens.

Mr. Owens's room does not know that about me yet. They are going to see what I do. They are going to see whether I raise my hand. They are going to see whether I sit alone at lunch. They are going to see whether I am the kid who makes a small joke when Mr. Owens makes an error on the board, or the kid who sits silently.

I have, in my hand, the ability to show up to first period as whatever Marcus I want to be.

This is a thing Ms. Calloway told us about, at our last meeting before summer. She said, *kids, you are about to walk into a building where most of the people in your classrooms will not know you. The version of you that they see is the version you choose to show. Be the version the cohort knows. Do not invent a new one. The cohort version is the real one. Be that one in the new rooms.*

I am thinking about that as the bell rings.

Mr. Owens stands up. *Good morning. I am Mr. Owens. Welcome to Algebra I.* The class settles.

Mr. Owens does the thing every first-day teacher does. He takes attendance. He goes around the room. He asks each of us to say our name and one thing we are interested in. *Lacey — horseback riding. Aaron — video games. Mary — marine biology.*

It comes around to me.

I say, *I am Marcus. I am* — I pause. I am, in my head, choosing between several options. I could say *interested in basketball*. True. I love basketball. I could say *interested in drawing comics*. Also true. I have been drawing one since fifth grade. I have not, until now, said this out loud to a room of strangers.

I could say *interested in storytelling*. That would be the grown-up version of the comic-drawing thing. It is the kind of answer that gets a teacher to nod and say *interesting*. It is not, exactly, a lie. It is just the polished version.

I think about Ms. Calloway. *Be the version the cohort knows.*

I say: *I am Marcus. I am interested in drawing comics. I have been drawing one for the last four years.*

Mr. Owens nods. *Interesting. What is the comic about.*

I had not been prepared for the follow-up. *It is about — it is about a kid who has a sister and they have adventures and there are a lot of small embarrassing things that happen. It is not — it is not a superhero comic. It is mostly about being embarrassed.*

The class laughs a little. I laugh a little. Mr. Owens says, *Marcus, that sounds great. I would love to see it sometime.* I say, *okay.*

The attendance keeps going. I sit there for a minute, processing. I have, in the first ten minutes of the first class of high school, told a room of strangers about the comic. I did not, before this morning, plan to. The choice happened in the third-row chair in the moment Mr. Owens asked the question.

I am going to be the comic-drawing kid in Algebra I. That is, by the end of today, going to be the thing Lacey-the-horseback-rider and Aaron-the-video-gamer and Mary-the-marine-biologist remember about me. *Marcus draws comics*. That is okay. That is true. That is the cohort version.

I am going to do this in every classroom today. I am going to do this in every classroom for the next four years. The Marcus the high school is going to know is going to be the Marcus the cohort knows.

That is the first decision of high school. That is — I am writing this in my journal that night, in my bedroom, after the first day — going to be the most important decision I make in the first month.

I am Marcus. I am fourteen. My voice cracks. I draw comics. I have eight other people in this building who have known me since first grade. I have one person in Pittsburgh I have been writing to for five years. I am in the freshman hallway. My locker is three down from Theo's. Ms. Calloway is going to be my English teacher tomorrow. The Mistake Wall is — Amara told me at lunch today — in the hallway right outside Room 104.

The building is big. I am small. But the cohort is in the building. And the cohort version of me is the one I am going to be.

That is the day.

END OF THE FIRST-CHAPTER PREVIEW

The version they see is the version you choose to show.

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Book Four of the five-book companion series to *The Architecture of Grace*